



## MOTHERBOARDS (AMD)

The Gigabyte GA-7NNXP board has a clean capacitor layout. Except for the floppy drive connector, all the other connectors are well placed.

Features-wise, there's an AGP Pro 8X slot, nVidia's onboard sound system, two LAN connectors, and support for a dual-channel DDR 400 MHz memory. It also features IDE RAID and S-ATA RAID functions, thus allowing maximum expandability in terms of storage. One unique feature is the Dual Power System (DPS) that can provide a six-phase supply to boost the voltages required during over-clocking. The board comes with 6 USB ports, 3 Firewire ports, an IR header and front USB ports.

We tested it with an AMD Athlon 3200+, 512 MB of DDR 400 MHz Corsair matched pair memory, an ATi 9800 128 MB graphics card and a Seagate Barracuda 40 GB hard disk, with Windows XP as the OS. In the SiSoft Sandra CPU test, the results were 8209 and 3297 respectively for the Dryhstones and Whetstones—the best so far for any AMD platform.

### Gigabyte GA-7NNXP

+ Top-of-the-line features  
– Expensive  
**Price:** Rs 15,000  
**Contact:** Digi Giga Systems Ltd  
**Phone:** 022-2652 6696  
**Fax:** 022-2652 8914  
**E-mail:** sales@dlink.co.in  
**Reviewed in:** December 2003



#### PREVIOUS WINNERS

**2002:** MSI KT4 Ultra  
**2001:** Asus A7M266

Quake III Arena saw it return a whopping 315 fps at 32-bit colour depth and a resolution of 1024 x 786. Video encoding a 50 MB file took just 72 seconds. The ZDbench Content Creation and Business Winstone benchmarks saw it give proof of the seamless working of all its sub-systems.

The price is rather high, but the

#### WORTHY MENTIONS

##### EPOX EP-8K3A

+ Feature-rich, onboard RAID controller, excellent value for money  
– No Serial ATA support  
**Price:** Rs 3,650  
**Contact:** Abacus Peripherals Pvt Ltd  
**Phone:** 022-5692 3941  
**Fax:** 022-5692 3946  
**E-mail:** enquiry@abacusperipherals.com  
**Reviewed in:** February 2003

##### DFI AD77 Infinity

+ Supports upto 4 GB memory  
– No Bluetooth support  
**Price:** Rs 7,000  
**Contact:** Zeta Technologies  
**Phone:** 022-2410 2288  
**Fax:** 022-2410 2277  
**E-mail:** tejas@zetaindia.com  
**Reviewed in:** February 2003

numerous features and the three-year warranty make up for it. All in all, it's the best motherboard for the AMD platform that money can buy.

## MOTHERBOARDS (INTEL)

The 865PE Neo2 is the latest entry from MSI for the Pentium 4 processor, which supports hyperthreading and 800 MHz FSB. It sports the usual clean layout, with no capacitors cramped around the CPU area. The dynamic over-clocking feature helps running CPU-intensive applications effectively.

The 865PE Neo2 comes with support for dual-channel DDR 400 MHz memory via four memory slots, Gigabit LAN, four S-ATA hard drive connectors and six-channel audio. The board has six onboard USB ports on the back panel and two in the front. The Firewire bracket connects to the board to provide 3 Firewire ports.

We tested the board with a Pentium4 3.2 GHz, an ATi 9800 128 MB card, Corsair 400 MHz matched pair memory, a 40 GB Seagate Barracuda hard drive and Windows XP as the OS. The results were absolutely stunning. The CPU tests saw it crossing the 10,000 mark on the Dryhstone value. Similarly, the multimedia FPU recorded an astounding 23,583 in the SiSoft Sandra benchmark, reflecting the superb CPU sub-system. In Quake 3

### 865PE Neo2

+ Great performance, dual-channel DDR 400  
– None  
**Price:** Rs 13,000  
**Contact:** Cyberstar  
**Phone:** 080-227 6986  
**Fax:** 080-223 6781  
**E-mail:** narend@cyberstarin.net  
**Reviewed in:** December 2003



#### PREVIOUS WINNERS

**2002:** Gigabyte GA-8ITXE  
**2001:** Asus P4T

Arena, it recorded a maximum of 556 fps in the fastest mode—this can be attributed to the 800 MHz FSB and the DDR 400 MHz. The video encoding was completed in just 71 seconds—one second ahead of the Gigabyte GA-7NNXP. The board returned 42.9 and 33.3 units in the

#### WORTHY MENTIONS

##### MSI 845PE Max2

+ Six-channel sound, Firewire port  
– No onboard display  
**Price:** Rs 7,000  
**Contact:** Cyberstar  
**Phone:** 080-227 6986  
**Fax:** 080-223 6781  
**E-mail:** narend@cyberstarin.net  
**Reviewed in:** February 2003

##### Mercury KOB845G-NDSMx

+ Excellent value for money  
– No overclocking possible  
**Price:** Rs 4,000  
**Contact:** Kobian India Ltd  
**Phone:** 080-556 6626  
**Fax:** 080-556 6625  
**E-mail:** india\_support@kobian.com  
**Reviewed in:** February 2003

content creation and Business Winstone benchmark respectively, posting the best scores till date.

At Rs 13,000, it's definitely expensive, but its features and mind-boggling performance more than make up for it. →